

Tamil Nadu

Tamil Nadu^[a] is the southernmost state of India. The tenth largest Indian state by area and the sixth largest by population, it is the home of the Tamils, who speak the Tamil language, the state's official language and the first to be recognised as a classical language in India. Chennai is the state's largest city and capital.

Located on the south-eastern coast of the Indian peninsula, Tamil Nadu is straddled by the Western Ghats and Deccan Plateau in the west, the Eastern Ghats in the north, the Eastern Coastal Plains lining the Bay of Bengal in the east, the Gulf of Mannar and the Palk Strait to the south-east, the Laccadive Sea at the southern cape of the peninsula, with the river Kaveri bisecting the state. Politically, Tamil Nadu is bound by the Indian states of Kerala, Karnataka, and Andhra Pradesh, and encloses a part of the union territory of Puducherry. It shares an international maritime border with the Northern Province of Sri Lanka at Pamban Island.

Archaeological evidence indicates that the Tamil Nadu region could have been inhabited more than 385,000 years ago by archaic humans. The state has more than 5,500 years of continuous cultural history. Historically, the Tamilakam region was inhabited by Tamil-speaking Dravidian people, who were ruled by several regimes over centuries such as the Sangam era triumvirate of the Cheras, Cholas and Pandyas, the Pallavas (3rd–9th century CE), and the later Vijayanagara Empire (14th–17th century CE). European colonisation began with establishing trade ports in the 17th century, with the British controlling much of the state as a part of the Madras Presidency for two centuries. After the Indian Independence in 1947, the region became the Madras State of the Republic of India and was further reorganised when states were redrawn linguistically in 1956 into its

Tamil Nadu

State



Shore Temple



Brihadisvara Temple



Thiruvalluvar Statue



Pamban Bridge



Hogenakkal Falls



Nilgiri Mountains

current shape. The state was renamed as Tamil Nadu, meaning "Tamil Country", in 1969. Hence, culture, cuisine and architecture have seen multiple influences over the years and have developed diversely.

As of December 2023, Tamil Nadu had an economy with a gross state domestic product (GSDP) of ₹27.22 trillion (US\$280 billion), making it the second-largest economy amongst the 28 states of India. It has the country's 9th-highest GSDP per capita of ₹315,220 (US\$3,300) and ranks 11th in human development index. Tamil Nadu is also one of the most industrialised states, with the manufacturing sector accounting for nearly one-third of the state's GDP. With its diverse culture and architecture, long coastline, forests and mountains, Tamil Nadu is home to a number of ancient relics, historic buildings, religious sites, beaches, hill stations, forts, waterfalls and four World Heritage Sites. The state's tourism industry is the largest among the Indian states. The state has three biosphere reserves, mangrove forests, five National Parks, 18 wildlife sanctuaries and 17 bird sanctuaries. The Tamil film industry, nicknamed as Kollywood, plays an influential role in the state's popular culture.

Etymology

The name is derived from Tamil language with *nadu* meaning "land" and Tamil Nadu meaning "the land of Tamils". The origin and precise etymology of the word Tamil is unclear with multiple theories attested to it.^[7] In the ancient Sangam literature, Tamilakam refers to the area of present-day Tamil Nadu, Kerala and parts of Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh. Tolkāppiyam (2nd to 1st century BCE) indicates the borders of Tamilakam as Tirumala and Kanniyakumari.^[8] The name *Tamilakam* is used in other Sangam era literature such as Purāṇānūru, Patirruppattu, Cilappatikaram, and Manimekalai.^[9] Cilappatikaram (5th to 6th century CE) and Ramavataram (12th century CE) mention the name *Tamil Nadu* to denote the region.^{[10][11][12]}



Emblem of Tamil Nadu

Etymology: Tamil Country
Nickname: "Land of Temples"
Motto: Vāymaiyē Vellum (Truth alone triumphs)
Anthem: "Tamil Thai Valthu"
("Invocation to Mother Tamil")



Location of Tamil Nadu in India

Coordinates: 11°N 79°E

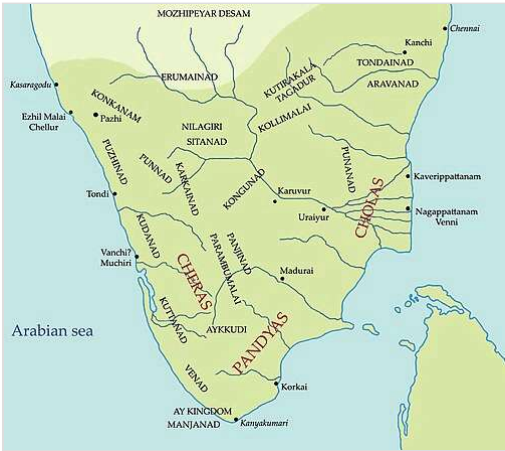
Country	India
Region	South India
Previously was	Madras State
Formation	1 November 1956
Capital and largest city	Chennai
Largest metro	Chennai metropolitan area
Districts	38
Government	
 • Body	Government of Tamil Nadu
 • Governor	Rajendra Arlekar
 • Chief Minister	C. Joseph Vijay (TVK)

History

Prehistory (before 5th century BCE)

Archaeological evidence indicates that the Tamil Nadu region could have been inhabited more than 385,000 years ago by archaic humans.^{[13][14]} Artifacts recovered in Adichanallur by the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) indicate a continuous history from more than 3,800 years ago.^[15] Neolithic celts with the Indus script dated between 1500 and 2000 BCE indicate the use of the Harappan language.^{[16][17]} Excavations at Keezhadi have revealed a large urban settlement, with the earliest artefact dated to 580 BCE, during the time of urbanisation in the Indo-Gangetic plain.^[18] Further epigraphical inscriptions found at Adichanallur use Tamil Brahmi, a rudimentary script dated to 5th century BCE.^[19] Potsherds uncovered from Keeladi indicate a script which might be a transition between the Indus Valley script and Tamil Brahmi script used later.^[20]

Sangam period (5th century BCE – 3rd century CE)



Tamilakam during the Sangam Period (500 BCE–300 CE)

The Sangam period lasted for about eight centuries, from 500 BCE to 300 CE with the main source of history during the period coming from the Sangam literature.^{[21][22]} Ancient Tamilakam was ruled by a triumvirate of monarchical states, Cheras, Cholas and

State Legislature Assembly	Unicameral Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly (234 seats)
National Parliament - Rajya Sabha - Lok Sabha	Parliament of India 18 seats 39 seats
High Court	Madras High Court
Area - Total - Rank	130,058 km² (50,216 sq mi) 10th
Dimensions Length	1,076 km (669 mi)
Highest elevation (Doddabetta)	2,637 m (8,652 ft)
Lowest elevation (Bay of Bengal)	0 m (0 ft)
Population (2011)^{[1][2]} - Total - Rank - Density - Urban - Rural	72,147,030 6th 554.7/km² (1,437/sq mi) 48.4% 51.6%
Demonyms	Tamilian • Tamilar
Language - Official - Additional official - Official script	Tamil^[3] English^[3] Tamil
GDP^{[4][5]} - Total (2024–25) - Rank - Per capita	▲ ₹31,159.98 billion (US\$330 billion) 2nd ▲ ₹350,695 (US\$3,700) (9th)
Time zone	UTC+05:30 (IST)
ISO 3166 code	IN-TN
Vehicle registration	TN
HDI (2025)	▲ 0.787 High (15th)
Literacy (2024)	85.5%^[6] (17th)
Sex ratio (2011)	996♀/1000 ♂ (3rd)
Website	tn.gov.in (http://tn.gov.in)
Symbols of Tamil Nadu	

Pandyas.^[23] The Cheras controlled the western part of Tamilkam, the Pandyas controlled the south, and the Cholas had their base in the Kaveri delta. The kings called *Vendhar* ruled over several tribes of *Velala* (peasants), headed by the *Velir* chiefs.^[24] The rulers patronised multiple religions including vedic religion, Buddhism and Jainism and sponsored some of the earliest Tamil literature with the oldest surviving work being Tolkāppiyam, a book of Tamil grammar.^[25]

The kingdoms had significant diplomatic and trade contacts with other kingdoms to the north and with the Romans.^[26] Much of the commerce from the Romans and Han China were facilitated via seaports including Muziris and Korkai with spices being the most prized goods along with pearls and silk.^{[27][28]} From 300 CE, the region was ruled by the Kalabhras, warriors belonging to the Vellalar community, who were once feudatories of the three ancient Tamil kingdoms.^[29] The Kalabhra era is referred to as the "dark period" of Tamil history, and information about it is generally inferred from any mentions in the literature and inscriptions that are dated many centuries after their era ended.^[30] The twin Tamil epics Cilappatikaram and Manimekalai were written during the era.^[31] Tamil classic Tirukkural by Thiruvalluvar, a collection of couplets is attributed to the same period.^{[32][33]}

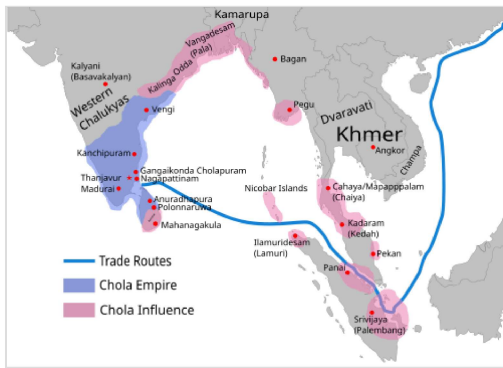
Medieval era (4th–13th century CE)

Around the 7th century CE, the Kalabhras were overthrown by the Pandyas and Cholas, who patronised Buddhism and Jainism before the revival of Saivism and Vaishnavism during the Bhakti movement.^[34] Though they existed previously, the period saw the rise of the Pallavas in the sixth century CE under Mahendravarman I, who ruled parts of South India with Kanchipuram as their capital.^[35] The Pallavas were noted for their patronage of architecture: the massive gopuram, ornate towers at the entrance of temples, originated with the Pallava architecture. They built the group of rock-cut monuments in Mahabalipuram and temples in Kanchipuram.^[36] Throughout their reign, the Pallavas remained in constant conflict with the Cholas and Pandyas. The Pandyas were revived by Kadungon towards the end of the 6th century CE and with the Cholas in obscurity in Uraiyur, the Tamil country was divided between the Pallavas and the Pandyas.^[37] The Pallavas were finally defeated by Chola prince Aditya I in the 9th century CE.^[38]

 Emblem of Tamil Nadu	
Song	<u>"Tamil Thai Valthu"</u> (<u>"Invocation to Mother Tamil"</u>)
Bird	<u>Emerald dove</u>
Butterfly	<u>Tamil yeoman</u>
Flower	<u>Gloriosa pily</u>
Fruit	<u>Jackfruit</u>
Mammal	<u>Nilgiri tahr</u>
Tree	<u>Asian palm</u>
State highway mark  State highway of Tamil Nadu TN SH1 - TN SH223	
<u>List of Indian state symbols</u>	



Rock cut monuments in Mahabalipuram built by the Pallavas



The Chola Empire at its greatest extent, during the reign of Rajendra Chola I in 1030

The Cholas became the dominant kingdom in the 9th century under Vijayalaya Chola, who established Thanjavur as Chola's new capital with further expansions by subsequent rulers. In the 11th century CE, Rajaraja I expanded the Chola Empire with conquests of entire Southern India and parts of present-day Sri Lanka and Maldives, and increased Chola influence across the Indian Ocean.^{[39][40]} Rajaraja brought in administrative reforms including the reorganisation of Tamil country into individual administrative units.^[41] Under his son Rajendra Chola I, the Chola Empire reached its zenith and stretched as far as Bengal in the north and across the Indian Ocean.^[42] The Cholas built many temples in the Dravidian style with the most notable being the Brihadisvara Temple at

Thanjavur, one of the foremost temples of the era built by Rajaraja, and Gangaikonda Cholapuram, built by Rajendra.^[43]

The Pandyas again reigned supreme early in the 13th century under Maravarman Sundara I.^[44] They ruled from their capital of Madurai and expanded trade links with other maritime empires.^[45] During the 13th century, Marco Polo mentioned the Pandyas as the richest empire in existence. The Pandyas also built a number of temples including the Meenakshi Amman Temple at Madurai.^[46]

Vijayanagar and Nayak period (14th–17th century CE)

In the 13th and 14th centuries, there were repeated attacks from Delhi Sultanate.^[47] The Vijayanagara kingdom was founded in 1336 CE.^[48] The Vijayanagara empire eventually conquered the entire Tamil country by c. 1370 and ruled for almost two centuries until its defeat in the Battle of Talikota in 1565 by a confederacy of Deccan sultanates.^{[49][50]} Later, the Nayaks, who were the military governors in the Vijayanagara Empire, took control of the region amongst whom the Nayaks of Madurai and Nayaks of Thanjavur were the most prominent.^{[51][52]} They introduced the palayakkarrar system and re-constructed some of the well-known temples in Tamil Nadu including the Meenakshi Temple in Madurai.^[53]

Later conflicts and European colonisation (17th to 20th century CE)

In the 18th century, the Mughal Empire administered the region through the Nawab of the Carnatic with his seat at Arcot, who defeated the Madurai Nayaks.^[54] The Marathas attacked several times and defeated the Nawab after the Siege of Trichinopoly (1751–1752).^{[55][56][57]} This led to a short-lived Thanjavur Maratha kingdom.^[58]

Europeans started to establish trade centres from the 16th century along the eastern coast. The Portuguese arrived in 1522 and built a port named São Tomé near present-day Mylapore in Madras.^[59] In 1609, the Dutch established a settlement in Pulicat and the Danes had their establishment in Tharangambadi.^{[60][61]} On 20 August 1639, Francis Day of the British East India Company met with the Vijayanagar emperor Peda Venkata Raya and obtained a grant for land on the Coromandel coast for their trading activities.^{[62][63][64]} A year later, the company built Fort St. George, the first major English settlement in India, which became the nucleus of the British Raj in the

region.^{[65][66]} By 1693, the French established trading posts at Pondichéry. In September 1746, the French captured Madras during the Battle of Madras.^[67] The British regained control of Madras in 1749 through the Treaty of Aix-la-Chapelle and resisted a French siege attempt in 1759.^{[68][69]} The British and French competed to expand the trade which led to Battle of Wandiwash in 1760 as part of the Seven Years' War.^[70] The Nawabs of the Carnatic surrendered much of their territory to the British East India Company in the north and bestowed tax revenue collection rights in the South, which led to constant conflicts with the Palaiyakkarars known as the Polygar Wars. Puli Thevar was one of the earliest opponents, joined later by Rani Velu Nachiyar of Sivagangai and Kattabomman of Panchalakurichi in the first series of Polygar wars.^{[71][72]} The Maruthu brothers along with Oomaithurai, the brother of Kattabomman, formed a coalition with Dheeran Chinnamalai and Kerala Varma Pazhassi Raja, which fought the British in the Second Polygar War.^[73] In the later 18th century, the Mysore kingdom captured parts of the region and engaged in constant fighting with the British which culminated in the four Anglo-Mysore Wars.^[74]



Fort Dansborg at Tharangambadi, built by the Danes



An 18th-century coloured engraving of Fort St. George and Madras

By the 18th century, the British had conquered most of the region and established the Madras Presidency with Madras as the capital.^[75] After the defeat of Mysore in the Fourth Anglo-Mysore War in 1799 and the British victory in the second Polygar war in 1801, the British consolidated most of southern India into what was later known as the Madras Presidency.^[76] On 10 July 1806, the Vellore mutiny, which was the first instance of a large-scale mutiny by Indian sepoys against the British East India Company, took place in Vellore Fort.^{[77][78]} After the Indian Rebellion of 1857, the British Parliament passed the Government of India Act 1858, which transferred the governance of India from the East India Company to the

British crown, forming the British Raj.^[79]

Failure of the summer monsoons and administrative shortcomings of the Ryotwari system resulted in two severe famines in the Madras Presidency, the Great Famine of 1876–1878 and the Indian famine of 1896–1897 which killed millions and the migration of many Tamils as bonded labourers to other British countries eventually forming the present Tamil diaspora.^[80] The Indian Independence movement gathered momentum in the early 20th century with the formation of the Indian National Congress, which was based on an idea propagated by the members of the Theosophical Society movement after a Theosophical convention held in Madras in December 1884.^{[81][82]} Tamil Nadu was the base of various contributors to the Independence movement including V. O. Chidambaram Pillai, Subramaniya Siva and Bharatiyar.^[83] The Tamils formed a significant percentage of the members of the Indian National Army (INA), founded by Subhas Chandra Bose.^[84]

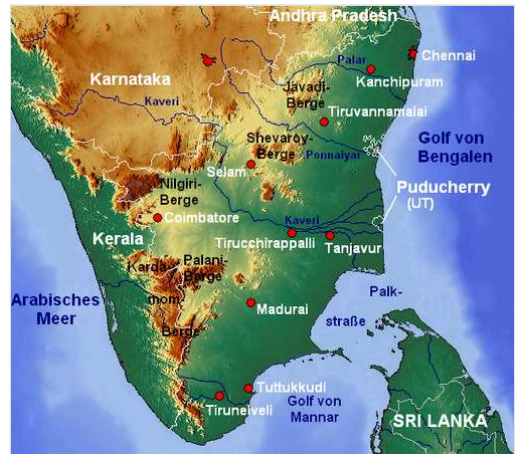
Post-Independence (1947–present)

After the Independence of India in 1947, the Madras Presidency became Madras state, comprising present-day Tamil Nadu and parts of Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and Kerala. Andhra state was split from the state in 1953 and the state was further reorganised when states were redrawn linguistically in 1956 into the current shape.^{[85][86]} On 14 January 1969, Madras state was renamed Tamil Nadu, meaning "Tamil country".^{[87][88]} In 1965, agitations against the imposition of Hindi and in support of continuing English as a medium of communication arose which eventually led to English being retained as an official language of India alongside Hindi.^[89] After independence, the economy of Tamil Nadu conformed to a socialist framework, with strict governmental control over private sector participation, foreign trade, and foreign direct investment. After experiencing fluctuations in the decades immediately after Indian independence, the economy of Tamil Nadu consistently exceeded national average growth rates from the 1970s, due to reform-oriented economic policies.^[90] In the 2000s, the state has become one of the most urbanised states in the country with a higher Human Development Index compared to national average.^[91]

Environment

Geography

Tamil Nadu covers an area of 130,058 km² (50,216 sq mi) and is the tenth-largest state in India.^[91] Located on the south-eastern coast of the Indian peninsula, Tamil Nadu is straddled by the Western Ghats and Deccan Plateau in the west, the Eastern Ghats in the north, the Eastern Coastal Plains lining the Bay of Bengal in the east, the Gulf of Mannar and the Palk Strait to the south-east, and the Laccadive Sea at the southern cape of the peninsula.^[92] Politically, Tamil Nadu is bound by the Indian states of Kerala, Karnataka, and Andhra Pradesh, and the union territory of Puducherry. It shares an international maritime border with the Northern Province of Sri Lanka at Pamban Island. The Palk Strait and the chain of low sandbars and islands known as Rama's Bridge separate the region from Sri Lanka, which lies off the southeastern coast.^{[93][94]} The southernmost tip of mainland India is at Kanyakumari where the Indian Ocean meets the Bay of Bengal and the Arabian Sea.^[95]



Topographic map of Tamil Nadu

The Western Ghats run south along the western boundary with the highest peak at Doddabetta (2,636 m (8,648 ft)) in the Nilgiri Hills.^{[96][97]} The Eastern Ghats run parallel to the Bay of Bengal along the eastern coast and the strip of land between them forms the Coromandel region.^[98] They are a discontinuous range of mountains intersected by Kaveri river.^[99] Both mountain ranges meet at the Nilgiri mountains which run in a crescent approximately along the borders of Tamil Nadu with northern Kerala and Karnataka, extending to the relatively low-lying hills of the Eastern Ghats on the western portion of the Tamil Nadu–Andhra Pradesh border.^[100] The Deccan Plateau is the elevated region bound by the mountain ranges and the plateau slopes gently from west to east resulting in